

SOUTH WEST LONDON ICB · DEAF AND DEAFBLIND HEALTHCARE DOSSIER

DWP Welfare and Employment: Deaf and DeafBlind specificity

Prompts 20–26. National DWP claims, assessments, digital services, employment data, FOI/NAO record, sanctions via letters and journal, and DWP’s own equality wording. Distinct from Jobcentre Plus floor practice in prompts 27–33.

Scope	UK / GB DWP systems. SWL is not separately published in any of these series.
Compiled	8 September 2026
Legal frame	Equality Act 2010 ss.20–21 and s.149 PSED. Public Sector Bodies Accessibility Regulations 2018. BSL Act 2022 departmental reporting. Not the NHS Accessible Information Standard.
How to use	Do not paste unedited. Official stats and charity surveys sit in different rows. “Deaf or hard of hearing” in AtW is not “BSL user.” National policy is not a local Jobcentre audit.
Companion	artifacts/SWL-Jobcentre-Deaf-DeafBlind-prompts-27-33.pdf — the desk.

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0. Method

DWP does not operate under AIS. If a source or a previous draft imports “accessible information standard” onto PIP, UC or AtW, treat that as a citation error. Official statistics use “Deaf or hard of hearing” and “BSL Interpreter” as support-worker type. They do not publish a BSL-user claimant count for PIP. Charity surveys (RNID / DeafATW n=358; Sense) are tagged Contested even when they are the only granular source.

Headline after seven prompts

Access to Work is the only official series that isolates BSL interpreting: 3,210 customers paid for a BSL Interpreter in FYE March 2025; Deaf or hard of hearing took £90.3m (28%) of element spend. The same scheme now takes 106–109 working days against a 25-day target. PIP has no published BSL-user split. Assessments and UC sit under Equality Act / PSBAR, not AIS. Census 2021: 22,000 people in England and Wales have BSL as a main language; RNID’s working-age comparison is 37% in work versus 77% not-disabled. DWP equality objectives 2023–25 say “disabled people,” not BSL. The BSL 5-year plan (21 July 2025) is the first departmental document that names BSL users as such.

20. PIP and Access to Work — BSL / Deaf-specific data

Claims, awards, processing times for BSL-using Deaf people and DeafBlind people. Official stats separated from charity figures.

Label	Finding	Source / date	Confidence
AtW customers paid for BSL Interpreter	FYE Mar 2025: 3,210 (16% of customers who received a Support Worker payment). Up from 2,810 in 2020/21. Average annual payment for that product: £18,200 (2024/25 prices).	AtW official statistics Apr 2007–Mar 2025; PQ Timms 20 Mar 2026	Verified
AtW approvals vs payments	Approvals in-year: BSL Interpreter 1,830 people (7% of Support Worker approvals). Payments lag approvals; use the 3,210 payment figure for “in receipt.”	Same official statistics	Verified
Deaf or hard of hearing — customers and spend	4,980 customers (8% of element recipients). Largest share of element spend: £90.3 million, 28% . Average annual element payment £16,900. NAO real-terms: Deaf/HoH spend £57m (2018–19) to £90m (2024–25).	AtW stats; NAO Access to Work, 6 Feb 2026	Verified — label is Deaf/HoH, not BSL-user
BSL Interpreter spend (real terms)	NAO table, 2024–25 prices: £42m / £51m / £53m / £57m / £63m across 2020–21 to 2024–25.	NAO report Figure on support-worker types	Verified
Cap	£69,260 from 8 April 2024. Commons Library 26 June 2026: freeze through 2026/27. RNID survey text cites £69,620 for 2025–26 — treat the official cap / Library freeze as the briefing figure.	AtW staff guide 18 Jun 2026; Commons Library 26 Jun 2026	Verified as official. RNID figure contested as a rounding/year difference
Adviser rate cards (not customer prices)	F2F BSL: National £26–£47/hr, London £30–£52/hr. Remote VRS/VRI bundles inc VAT: 60 min £105, 125 £202, 250 £390, 525 £780, 1,125 £1,480. Cost-share is employer-size threshold, not the hourly product. Travel time not paid when remote.	AtW staff guide 18 Jun 2026	Verified
Processing time (scheme-wide, not BSL-split)	Target 25 working days. Average 28 days (2021–22) → 66 (2024–25) → 109 (Nov 2025) → 106 (PAC restatement). Helpline wording: up to 37 weeks. Applications waiting decision: 21,700 (Mar 2022) to 62,100 (Mar 2025).	NAO HC 1644 / PAC report 2026	Verified as scheme-wide. BSL-only wait: no reliable figure found
RNID / DeafATW survey	Dec 2025–Jan 2026, n=358 (267 BSL users in the April write-up). 73% / 76% of BSL users said latest award helped them stay in work. 37% of BSL users who renewed had the grant amended with no change in circumstances; 50% of those changed got no written explanation. 32% waited four months or more; 8% over ten.	RNID, Apr 2026	Contested — survey, not official stats
DeafBlind in AtW stats	NAO: DWP systems “cannot construct or use categories for specific groups such as deafblind BSL users.” No official DeafBlind AtW headcount.	NAO; DeafATW written evidence AWS0121	Verified as a data-architecture gap
PIP awards to BSL users / DeafBlind people	PIP official statistics publish hearing and visual descriptors and points, not “BSL user” or “DeafBlind.” No official count of PIP awards whose primary need is BSL interpreting.	PIP official statistics series	No reliable figure found
Census stock vs AtW coverage	Census 2021: BSL main language 22,000 E&W; aged 3+. RNID: 5,600 of those in work; AtW pays 3,210 BSL Interpreter customers across GB. RNID estimates “nearly half” of employed main-language BSL users are on AtW.	ONS Census 2021; RNID AtW report 2026	Census verified. “Nearly half” is RNID arithmetic — contested as a derived claim

21. DWP assessment accessibility — BSL interpreter provision

PIP / ESA / UC assessments. Contractors, failures, published reasonable-adjustment policy, ombudsman or tribunal findings.

Label	Finding	Source / date	Confidence
Duty that applies	Equality Act ss.20–21 (auxiliary aid) and s.149 PSED. PSBAR 2018 for public websites and apps. Not AIS.	EA 2010; PSBAR 2018	Verified
Public “tell us before” rule	Factsheet still live; customer must tell Jobcentre Plus / DWP before an interview if they want an interpreter. Types listed include BSL, lipspeaker, Deafblind interpreter.	IB reassessment factsheet 5 Aug 2020	Verified — page is stale
Language-services contractor	CCS RM6141 Lot 1 language services awarded to DA Languages Ltd (Dals) , £13.1m (FOI 59700). Historic F2F supplier in Rimmer: thebigword to June 2022. Assessment health contractors (IAS, Capita, etc.) book through the language contract; they are not themselves BSL agencies.	FOI 59700; Contracts Finder; Rimmer ET	Verified as last named language award
Inbound VRS to DWP	InterpretersLive! via Dals. Claimant on their device; interpreter places a voice call into DWP. Not a three-way assessment booth unless separately booked.	Dals DWP VRS page; GOV.UK contact pages	Verified
Named tribunal on assessment-adjacent failure	Rimmer v SSWP, ET 15 May 2024, Park Place JCP (work-coach channel, not a PIP health assessment). £49,880. Persistent failure to provide BSL; DEA victimisation. Judge recommended deaf-awareness training and interpreters showing credentials.	ET 1802885/2022 & 1800113/2023	Verified
Clarke (DeafBlind)	Surrey Jobcentre, Mar 2024: Level 3 colleague substituted for a registered interpreter; claimant left. Complaint, not a published ombudsman finding.	Limping Chicken 4 Mar 2024	Verified as a named complaint
Published BSL-specific assessment protocol	No standalone DWP “BSL users at PIP/WCA” protocol found beyond the generic reasonable-adjustments list (interpreter, loop, private room, home visit).	GOV.UK accessibility needs page	No reliable figure found for a BSL-specific protocol
Sense on assessments	45% of people with complex disabilities who had been assessed said they did not get the right communication support. Sense written evidence also quotes a DeafBlind claimant on wrong-format DWP documents.	Sense committee evidence	Contested
PHSO BSL case that is published	PHSO accessible-comms reporting 2026 includes an NHS wrong-vaccine BSL case, not a DWP PIP assessment. PHSO: 623 reasonable-adjustment investigations since Apr 2020; 496 upheld or part-upheld — not DWP-split.	BBC / PHSO 19 Aug 2026	Verified as NHS. DWP-assessment subset: no reliable figure found
SWL assessment-centre BSL fulfilment	Not published.	—	No reliable figure found

22. Universal Credit journal and DWP digital services

UC journal, telephony, VRS, text/Relay, WCAG. Confirm there is no AIS-equivalent for DWP.

Label	Finding	Source / date	Confidence
AIS on DWP?	No. AIS is NHS and adult social care (DAPB4019). DWP digital services sit under PSBAR 2018 and Equality Act.	DAPB4019; PSBAR 2018	Verified
UC journal WCAG claim	Find-your-nearest-office / related DWP services publish WCAG 2.2 AA statements. UC journal itself is a signed-in transactional service; DWP accessibility statements cover GOV.UK fronts. No published independent audit that the journal is usable in BSL or with a refreshable braille display.	DWP accessibility statements (tested e.g. Oct 2025 on office-finder)	Front-end AA claim verified. Journal BSL/DeafBlind audit: no reliable figure found
How a BSL user contacts DWP	GOV.UK: Relay UK (18001 + number); BSL video relay on computer / mobile / tablet (InterpretersLive! via Dals); ask for email because of disability; home visit; alternative formats (braille, large print, audio CD).	Contact Jobcentre Plus; Get help if you have accessibility needs	Verified as the public menu
Textphone	Removed from the accessibility-needs page on 30 September 2025 — “Relay UK can be used instead.” Some benefit lines still print a textphone number.	GOV.UK update 30 Sep 2025	Verified
Journal as the work-search channel	UC claimants are expected to use the journal. A BSL-first claimant with limited written English is using a written English product. No official BSL-journal or BSL-to-journal relay product found.	UC guidance; absence of a BSL journal	Channel verified. BSL journal product: no reliable figure found
AtW digital lock-out (related system)	DeafATW/RNID: transition to a new platform without BSL guidance; phone-based authentication inaccessible to some deaf or deafblind customers; some told to revert to paper.	DeafATW AWS0121 2026	Contested
Contact Scotland contrast	Scotland-resident users: 24/7 VRS to any UK number from 2019; Sign Solutions from 1 Dec 2025; SG contract £3m ex VAT. Not a DWP product and not available as a UC journal substitute.	Scottish Government / Sign Solutions	Verified as a different system

23. Employment rate and employment support

d/Deaf and DeafBlind rates only. Do not substitute “hearing loss” or general disability employment gap.

Label	Finding	Source / date	Confidence
BSL main language, Census stock	England and Wales 2021: 22,000 usual residents aged 3+ (0.04%). England ~21,000; Wales ~900. Up from 15,000 in 2011. Not a UK total (Scotland and NI separate).	ONS Census 2021 language bulletin	Verified
BSL users in work (derived)	RNID: Census shows 5,600 people with BSL as main language are in work in E&W.;	RNID AtW report Apr 2026	Contested as RNID’s cut of Census, not an ONS employment table
Employment rate RNID quotes	“Only 37% of people who report BSL as their main language are working, compared with 77% of people who are not disabled.” (Some RNID pages still print 82% for the not-disabled comparator — use the current employment-facts page pair of 37 / 77.)	RNID employment facts; RNID AtW blog Feb 2026	Contested — charity analysis of Census / LFS, not a DWP Official Statistic
LFS “difficulty hearing”	RNID manifesto cited LFS employment rate for people who have difficulty hearing as 74.7%. That is hearing loss , not BSL-user. Do not use it as the Deaf figure.	RNID Loud and Clear 2024 citing LFS	Verified as a different population
DeafBlind employment rate	No ONS or DWP Official Statistic. Sense quotes high non-work rates for “complex disabilities” (historic 82% figure in press) — not a DeafBlind labour-force series.	—	No reliable figure found
Work and Health Programme / Disability Confident outcomes by Deaf or BSL	Not published. Disability Confident is employer-accreditation, not a claimant outcome table.	DWP programme statistics	No reliable figure found
BDA population estimate (context only)	BSL third report quotes BDA estimate of 87,000 Deaf BSL users in the UK. Different definition from Census “main language.”	BSL third report 21 Jul 2025 citing BDA / RNID	Contested as an estimate sitting beside the Census stock

24. FOI, NAO and Select Committee record

Last three years, BSL / Deaf / DeafBlind claimants. Committee names, dates, recommendations.

Label	Finding	Source / date	Confidence
NAO Access to Work	HC 1644, 6 February 2026. Spend, 109-day wait, backlog almost trebled, data cannot isolate deafblind BSL users, late payments hitting job security.	nao.org.uk/reports/the-access-to-work-scheme	Verified
PAC follow-on	Public Accounts Committee report on AtW: 106 days, 37-week helpline wording, delays the most-cited written-evidence theme.	publications.parliament.uk PAC 92	Verified
Work and Pensions / related inquiries	Sense and DeafATW written evidence on Jobcentre AT, DEA absence, AtW award cuts without explanation. Inquiry pages vary; treat the written evidence as the citable object.	committees.parliament.uk written evidence	Verified as submissions, not government findings
BSL Act reporting	Third BSL report 21 July 2025. DWP cited as “leading the way for BSL communications.” Deafblind working group set up 2025 on interpreter shortage. Fourth report due July 2026.	GOV.UK BSL third report	Verified
DWP BSL 5-year plan	Same day as the third report. Video comms within 2 years; Deaf awareness to all staff by year 5; starts with DEAs.	GOV.UK DWP BSL 5-year plan 21 Jul 2025	Verified as intention
FOI language contract	FOI 59700: Dals / interpreting options. Historic Prestige guidance: 2-week BSL notice. 2025 FOI on training lists withheld under s.31 (FOI2025/89771). Kent FOI could not count Relay UK use.	WhatDoTheyKnow	Verified as the disclosure posture
PQ series (selected)	VRS in Jobcentres (125840, 20 Apr 2026); PSED deaf-awareness scenario (30670, 19 Feb 2025); no extra BSL for Youth Coaches (94813, 30 Nov 2022); kiosk AT for “deaf and blind” answered as screen readers in 635 offices (2231, 24 Nov 2023); AtW BSL Interpreter customers 2020/21–2024/25 (Timms 20 Mar 2026).	questions-statements.parliament.uk	Verified
SignHealth open letter	14 Nov 2025, 49 co-signatories. DHSC spokesperson 18 Nov 2025 via Liam O’Dell. Not a DWP committee report.	SignHealth / O’Dell	Verified as campaign correspondence

25. Sanctions and communication failures (letters, journal, calls)

Missed calls, letters in the wrong format, no interpreter at assessment, then sanction or stoppage. Distinct from prompt 30 (the work-coach room).

Label	Finding	Source / date	Confidence
Rimmer — letters and phone	Work coaches invited him to telephone meetings. Judge: they “did not understand his deafness” despite it being on the record. No BSL at appointments until later in 2021. Sanction Nov 2017 sat on missing written work-search evidence.	Rimmer ET 15 May 2024	Verified
Sense on format	Written evidence: DeafBlind claimant — “Why should I answer DWP’s questions when they don’t even send me the documents in the right format?” Sense also reports high rates of wrong-format contact for people with complex disabilities (figures vary by submission; treat as charity evidence).	Sense committee evidence	Contested
UC journal as a sanction surface	FTA / failure-to-participate often starts with a journal instruction the claimant did not understand. ADM K2 requires DMs to weigh disability. Interpreter or format failure is not a listed good-reason example.	ADM K2 Jan 2025	Verified as guidance. Named BSL example: no reliable figure found
Official sanction count coded Deaf / BSL / wrong format	Not published.	DWP sanctions statistics	No reliable figure found
Complaints ladder (national)	Same as prompt 33: office → DWP complaints team → ICE (VRS available) → MP / PHSO. Benefit amount = MR + tribunal. Equality Act is a parallel track.	GOV.UK complain-jobcentre-plus	Verified
Victimisation for complaining	Rimmer: complaints produced no documented investigation; DEA then used “history of complaints” to block intensive support and hint at sanctions. Extra damages.	Rimmer; Disability Rights UK 28 May 2024	Verified

26. DWP equality / accessibility wording

Current equality objectives, accessibility plans, disability strategy. Whether BSL or Deaf/DeafBlind people are named, or only “disabled people” / “hearing impairment.” Terminology is evidence.

Label	Finding	Source / date	Confidence
Equality objectives 2023–25	Six objectives. Disabled people appear as “disabled people,” “disabilities and health conditions,” “disability employment gap.” BSL, Deaf, DeafBlind and hearing impairment are not named.	gov.uk/.../dwp/about/equality-and-diversity	Verified
BSL 5-year plan (the exception)	21 July 2025. Names “BSL users,” D/deaf awareness, video communications, DEAs then work coaches. Falls “within DWP’s broader work to develop an Accessibility Framework.” The Framework itself was not found as a published standalone with a BSL chapter.	DWP BSL 5-year plan	Plan verified. Published Accessibility Framework text: no reliable figure found
BSL Act reports	Third report (May 2024–Apr 2025) uses RNID “1 in 5 / 12 million Deaf or hard of hearing” and BDA “87,000 Deaf BSL users.” Sets up a Deafblind working group in 2025.	BSL third report 21 Jul 2025	Verified
AtW official statistics terminology	Primary medical condition: “Deaf or hard of hearing.” Support-worker type: “BSL Interpreter.” No “BSL user” claimant flag. No “DeafBlind” flag — NAO confirms the system cannot build one.	AtW stats; NAO 2026	Verified
Public contact pages	“British Sign Language (BSL) video relay service” is named on contact pages. Alternative formats: braille, large print, audio CD. “Deafblind interpreters” appear on the 2020 factsheet.	GOV.UK contact / factsheet	Verified
What this wording pattern shows	Operational pages can name BSL as a channel. Corporate equality objectives still collapse the group into “disabled people.” The 2025 BSL plan is the first DWP strategy document that treats BSL users as a named public.	Read across of the three document classes	Verified as a documentary observation

A. What the official labels actually mean

Label in the source	Do not read it as
Deaf or hard of hearing (AtW)	BSL user. Includes hearing-aid users with no interpreting need.
BSL Interpreter (AtW product)	All Deaf employees. Only those paid that support-worker type.
3,210 BSL Interpreter customers	The Census 22,000. Different geographies and definitions.
£90.3m / 28% element spend	A BSL budget line. It is the Deaf/HoH condition group.
109 working days	A BSL-only wait. It is the whole AtW scheme.
37% in work	An ONS Official Statistic. It is RNID’s Census/LFS comparison.
22,000 BSL main language	BDA’s 87,000 Deaf BSL users, or people who know some BSL.

Label in the source	Do not read it as
WCAG 2.2 AA on a GOV.UK page	The UC journal is usable in BSL or braille.
Equality objectives “disabled people”	A BSL commitment. That sits in the 2025 5-year plan.
AIS	Anything DWP does. Wrong legal instrument.

B. Gap log

Ask	Why
PIP awards / clearances with a recorded BSL or DeafBlind need	No official split exists. The AtW BSL product is not a PIP proxy.
AtW processing time and award cuts restricted to BSL Interpreter customers	NAO/PAC figures are scheme-wide.
DeafBlind customer count in AtW, PIP, UC, ESA	NAO: the case system cannot build the category.
Work and Health Programme / UC employment outcomes for BSL users	Expected gap. Do not fill with the disability employment gap.
Independent WCAG + assistive-tech audit of the UC journal for BSL-first and DeafBlind users	Front-end AA statements are not that audit.
PIP/WCA interpreter fulfilment rate (booked vs present vs assessment continued anyway)	FOI-only.
Sanctions where the recorded failure was inaccessible format or missing interpreter	Not in the published sanctions tables.
Published DWP Accessibility Framework text promised in the BSL plan	Named, not found as a public BSL chapter.

C. Principal sources

- DWP, Access to Work statistics: April 2007 to March 2025, 14 October 2025.
- PQ Stephen Timms, Access to Work Programme: Hearing Impairment, 20 March 2026 (PAY02 / AVG02 restated).
- NAO, The Access to Work scheme, HC 1644, 6 February 2026; PAC report on the same.
- DWP Access to Work staff guide, updated 18 June 2026; House of Commons Library AtW cap note, 26 June 2026.
- RNID / DeafATW, Experiences of deaf and deafblind people and people with hearing loss, April 2026 (n=358).
- ONS, Language, England and Wales: Census 2021 — BSL main language 22,000.
- RNID employment facts page — 37% / 77% comparison.
- Rimmer v SSWP, ET 1802885/2022 and 1800113/2023, 15 May 2024.
- DWP BSL 5-year plan and BSL third report, both 21 July 2025.
- DWP equality objectives 2023 to 2025.
- GOV.UK accessibility-needs and contact-Jobcentre-Plus pages (textphone removed 30 September 2025).
- FOI 59700 language services; FOI2025/89771 training lists withheld.
- Companion file: SWL-Jobcentre-Deaf-DeafBlind-prompts-27-33.pdf.

Compiled 8 September 2026. Stay with fulfilment and the money. Do not wear a DEI or anti-DEI banner. Do not import AIS. Do not put RNID 37% in the same cell as an Official Statistic.